

The 2026 Nonprofit and Community Services Opportunity Playbook

A source-backed guide to grants, cooperative agreements, contracts, subawards, intermediaries, local implementation, and policy signals.

6 lanes Grant, contract, subaward, intermediary, local, and policy routes	Fit first Mission alignment is not eligibility	30 days A capacity-aware funding plan
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Built for founders and revenue teams that need credible targets, clear revenue motions, contact paths, and next actions - not a generic list of grants or contracts.

Opportunity Scanner by Opportunity Systems

Research current as of July 27, 2026. Always recheck time-sensitive official sources before acting.

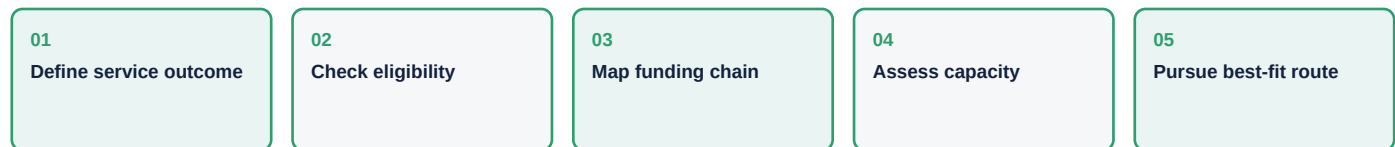
The opportunity landscape

Use these lanes to separate records that imply different buyers, partners, timing, and next actions.

6 evidence lanes to investigate



From signal to an owned revenue action



These diagrams are operating maps, not a promise that every lane is open. The report explains the evidence, constraints, and qualification checks behind each route.

Updated July 27, 2026. Open opportunities, agency forecasts, award status, program rules, and local competitions are time-sensitive and must be rechecked before action.

Offer and audience

This guide is for nonprofit executives, development teams, community-based organizations, human-services providers, workforce and housing organizations, faith-based service organizations, and partnership teams seeking sustainable public-sector revenue.

Conversion promise: Learn how to identify where public money enters a community, distinguish the role your organization could play, and use Opportunity Scanner to turn official records into qualified pursuits. This report does not determine eligibility, guarantee funding, replace a Notice of Funding Opportunity (NOFO), or provide legal, accounting, procurement, lobbying, or grant-compliance advice.

Executive brief

The public-sector market for community services is a delivery network, not a single grants portal. Federal agencies may make direct grants or cooperative agreements, send formula or block-grant funds to states, fund a local government or regional intermediary, or buy services through a contract. Those primary recipients may then issue subawards, procure vendors, designate local providers, or build coalitions. A nonprofit can therefore be a direct applicant, subrecipient, contractor, implementation partner, referral partner, or informed monitor of a future program.

The central research mistake is to treat every record as an open grant. A posted NOFO can support a Direct Apply motion. A state formula award is usually money-flow evidence that points to a state agency, local board, or downstream competition. A historical recipient record can reveal an experienced intermediary, potential partner, incumbent, or future buyer, but it does not prove current availability. A policy notice or forecast can justify preparation and monitoring, not an application.

The opportunity is clearest when evidence is converted into five decisions: what is happening, who controls the next decision, what role fits the organization, how that decision-maker can appropriately be reached, and what action will reduce uncertainty. Opportunity Scanner should accelerate that work while preserving the official source and its limitations.

State of the market in July 2026

Trend 1: Community-service funding commonly reaches the front line through layers

Federal programs often place states, local governments, commissions, workforce boards, Continuums of Care, or other intermediaries between the federal agency and front-line providers. DOL publishes Program Year 2026 WIOA allotments to states and outlying areas; implementation involves state plans, local workforce areas, boards, and the American Job Center system. HHS describes the Community Services Block Grant as funding a community-action network while allowing states flexibility around priorities. These distinct programs show why a federal award can begin local research.

Searching only Grants.gov can miss state solicitations, county RFPs, board procurements, coalition selections, and subrecipient opportunities. Trace each relevant program at least one level downstream.

Trend 2: The funding instrument determines the relationship

Grants.gov explains that contracts acquire property or services for an agency's benefit. Grants and cooperative agreements transfer value for a public purpose; cooperative agreements anticipate substantial agency involvement. A grant proposal centers on outcomes and allowable activities; a contract response centers on requirements, deliverables, pricing, and procurement terms.

Mission fit alone does not establish the right pursuit. Read the instrument and full notice before assigning a revenue motion, budget, or proposal owner.

Trend 3: Local competitions can begin before the federal deadline

For FY2026 AmeriCorps State and National, single-state applicants generally applied through a Governor-appointed commission. AmeriCorps set a March 31, 2026 federal deadline but warned that commissions could impose earlier deadlines and additional requirements. HUD's FY2026 Continuum of Care registration ran April 1-23, 2026, before detailed competition resources.

These examples are program-specific, but commission, coalition, and intermediary calendars can control access. Monitor the local or state body alongside the federal source.

Trend 4: Historical awards are useful market evidence, with careful definitions

USAspending covers prime contracts, grants, cooperative agreements, subcontracts, and subgrants. It defines an obligation as a promise to spend, an outlay as money paid, and a subaward as a prime recipient's agreement with another entity to perform part of the award. HHS TAGGS provides HHS-specific award and recipient searches.

These records can reveal geography, program continuity, incumbents, and partners; they do not prove available funds, buying intent, or recurrence. Preserve the period, award type, Assistance Listing, measure, recipient, and place of performance. Label the result historical unless a current source proves otherwise.

Trend 5: Post-award capacity belongs in qualification

The 2024 Uniform Guidance revision applies to awards issued on or after October 1, 2024, subject to agency implementation and award terms. Current rules allow eligible recipients and subrecipients without a negotiated rate to elect up to a 15 percent de minimis indirect rate, and generally require an audit when a non-federal entity expends at least \$1 million in federal awards during its fiscal year. These are compliance rules, not accounting recommendations.

Qualify reimbursement timing, match, indirect costs, reporting, data, staffing, and audit readiness before committing proposal resources.

Trend 6: Current status requires active monitoring

Official pages can mix forecasted, posted, amended, closed, archived, awarded, and registration-only records. In July 2026, HUD distinguishes completed FY2026 registration from forthcoming competition resources while preserving FY2024 awards. A forecast supplies lead time, not a promise.

Assign every forecast, policy signal, and pre-competition record a next-check date and owner. Recheck before outreach, board approval, or submission.

Eight opportunity lanes

Lane	What the evidence can show	Likely revenue motion	First validation
Direct grant	Posted NOFO for a public-purpose project	Direct Apply	Eligibility, status, deadline, match, allowable activities
Cooperative agreement	Assistance award with substantial agency involvement	Direct Apply	Expected federal involvement, milestones, staffing, governance
Formula or block-grant flow	Federal funds assigned to states or other eligible governments	Sell to Funded Buyer; Partner with Recipient	State administering agency and downstream allocation process
Subaward	Prime recipient delegates part of a federal program	Partner with Recipient; Direct Apply to intermediary	Whether the relationship is truly a subaward and how selection occurs
Government contract	Agency or local government acquires services or goods	Sell to Agency	Procurement portal, scope, vehicle, vendor requirements, due date
Recipient procurement	Funded nonprofit, government, or intermediary buys implementation support	Sell to Funded Buyer; Sell to Award Recipient	Purchasing authority, procurement rules, budget fit, timing
Coalition or local implementation	Local body ranks, coordinates, endorses, or selects providers	Partner with Recipient	Governance, membership, local calendar, decision process
Policy or future-funding signal	Rule, plan, forecast, registration, hearing, or agency notice	Monitor Policy; Research Only	Proposed versus final, effective date, next milestone, named owner

The Opportunity Scanner workflow

Step 1: Build a delivery profile before searching

Describe populations, services, outcomes, evidence, geography, delivery sites, referrals, languages, licenses, current awards, data capacity, unit economics, and expansion limits. Record constraints such as reimbursement dependence, match, cash reserves, insurance, credentialing, and service boundaries.

Translate the profile into public-sector problem language. A youth nonprofit might map to afterschool enrichment, disconnected youth, workforce pathways, violence prevention, mentoring, family stabilization, and summer employment.

Output: five to ten mission-and-delivery concepts, target geographies, and explicit exclusions for Opportunity Scanner.

Step 2: Run a broad scan, then separate source purposes

Use Opportunity Scanner across Grants.gov, SAM.gov, USAspending, award systems, program pages, official local sites, and policy sources. Group results by what each source can prove:

- Grants.gov: federal assistance opportunities, status, eligibility summaries, dates, and instructions.
- SAM.gov: program Assistance Listings plus federal contract notices and amendments.
- USAspending and TAGGS: award, recipient, subaward, geography, and money-flow history.
- Agency and local pages: rules, calendars, plans, awards, provider selections, and contacts.
- Federal Register and Regulations.gov: policy, notices, dockets, comments, and effective dates.

Output: a source-grouped candidate list, not yet a pipeline.

Step 3: Verify the live record

Open every promising official record. Capture its identifier, Assistance Listing, instrument, office, status, amended dates, project period, geography, eligibility, cost share, stated award range, and source contact. Read the attached NOFO or solicitation; the summary is not controlling.

For awards, distinguish amount, obligations, and outlays, and compare recipient location with place of performance. Preserve local jurisdiction and fiscal or program year.

Output: a verified record with an as-of date and caveat.

Step 4: Trace the money and classify the organization's role

Draw the shortest defensible chain: federal agency -> state or prime recipient -> local intermediary -> provider or vendor. Then classify the desired relationship.

Under 2 CFR 200.331, substance controls. A subrecipient carries out part of a federal program; a contractor provides goods or services through procurement. The pass-through entity decides case by case.

Output: one primary target, one role, and one revenue motion.

Step 5: Apply the qualification scorecard

Use High, Medium, or Low rather than false numerical precision.

Dimension	High-quality evidence	Downgrade or reject when
Mission and service fit	Allowable work matches demonstrated delivery	Fit depends on broad words or a new, unproven program
Eligibility	Full instructions clearly include the entity type	Eligibility is inferred from a general program page
Geography and population	Service area and beneficiaries match current reach	Expansion assumptions are unsupported
Timing	Active calendar and milestones are verified	Record is expired, forecasted, or historical without a monitor plan

Dimension	High-quality evidence	Downgrade or reject when
Financial fit	Match, reimbursement, indirect cost, and cash needs are workable	Award size is attractive but delivery financing is unclear
Operating capacity	Staffing, partners, data, compliance, and governance are credible	Application depends on capacity that cannot be ready in time
Target and motion	Decision-maker and role are named	"Contact the government" is the strategy
Source confidence	Official source supports the claim and status	Aggregator or snippet substitutes for the controlling document

High Actionability requires strong fit, verified timing, a named target, a realistic role, and an owned next action. Medium Actionability needs defined validation. Low Actionability remains context, monitoring, or a documented rejection.

Step 6: Build the contact path

Match contact to question. Use the official program contact for permitted NOFO questions and the contracting officer, procurement mailbox, bidder conference, or portal for procurement. Ask pass-through entities about their selection calendar and process.

For intermediaries, research program, grants, partnerships, procurement, or implementation roles. Prefer an official office, public meeting, bidder process, or role-based route when appropriate. Never seek preferential application advice.

Output: contact purpose, official route, recommended role, message angle, and fallback research task.

Step 7: Move only qualified signals into workflow

Each Opportunity Action Table row needs a source and date, evidence type, status, target, revenue motion, actionability, contact path, fit, caveat, next action, owner, and due date.

Useful actions include confirming a calendar, checking SAM registration, validating match, requesting a bidder list, identifying an incumbent, or holding a bid/no-bid review. Name the exact unknown and source.

How to pursue each route

Grants and cooperative agreements

Start with legal eligibility, then test program fit. Build a NOFO matrix: requirement, evidence, owner, due date, and source page. Confirm registrations early; federal applicants need active SAM.gov registration and a UEI, and registrations renew every 365 days. For cooperative agreements, plan for anticipated agency involvement.

Before a go decision, model direct and indirect costs, match, reimbursement lag, reporting, evaluation, partners, procurement, and closeout. Forecast amounts remain provisional until posted.

Subawards and funded intermediaries

Find prime recipients in USAspending, TAGGS, agency announcements, or state lists. Verify purpose and period, then search recipient sites for partner requests, subrecipient competitions, procurement notices, plans, and provider lists.

Offer a specific contribution: geography, trusted access, capacity, evidence, referrals, language, or data. Ask about process and timing. A prior subaward proves a route, not a new round.

Contracts and recipient procurement

Treat contracts and recipient purchases as buying motions. Confirm whether the buyer needs a vendor, partner, or both. Map scope, codes, insurance, licensing, past performance, pricing, and calendar.

Historical contracts reveal incumbents and patterns; forecasts provide lead time. Neither is active. Consider teaming when prime readiness is weak, while distinguishing a subcontract from a grant subaward.

Local implementation and policy monitoring

Read state plans, local budgets, board packets, commission calendars, needs assessments, consolidated plans, CoC materials, and hearing notices. They can reveal priorities before a solicitation.

Track proposed and final actions separately. Record identifier, comment deadline, effective date, agency, program, and milestone. Route public comments through policy and legal controls. Set a dated trigger for the next review.

Worked illustrative example

Organization context: A regional nonprofit provides housing navigation, benefits enrollment, and employment support for young adults.

Signals: A historical HUD award report identifies the local Continuum of Care and funded projects. The current HUD page shows the FY2026 registration stage and says detailed competition resources are forthcoming. A DOL Program Year 2026 allotment confirms workforce funds flow to the state, while the state plan and local workforce board identify implementation structures.

Interpretation: None of these records alone is an open award for the nonprofit. Together they identify two credible local systems, their intermediaries, and the next calendars to monitor.

Primary motion: Partner with Recipient by entering the Continuum of Care's local process with a defined youth housing and employment contribution.

Secondary motion: Sell to Funded Buyer or pursue a subaward through the local workforce board, depending on how that board classifies and procures the service.

Contact path: CoC Collaborative Applicant or lead agency for competition process; local workforce board program or procurement office for provider selection.

Next action: Verify the CoC's local ranking calendar and the workforce board's active provider procurements, then hold an internal capacity review covering match, data sharing, staffing, and cash flow. This example is illustrative and does not claim that either system is currently purchasing these services.

30-day action plan

Days 1-5: Establish readiness

Complete the delivery profile, confirm SAM.gov and Grants.gov roles if direct federal applications are in scope, identify financial and geographic limits, and select three service themes. Assign one executive owner and one operational owner.

Days 6-10: Scan the full money flow

Run Opportunity Scanner for direct opportunities, Assistance Listings, historical awards, subawards, contracts, policy notices, and state or local implementation records. Keep the top 15 to 20 candidates; preserve weaker records only when they reveal a useful route or future trigger.

Days 11-15: Verify and classify

Open every official source. Label each record active opportunity, forecast, historical market evidence, funded intermediary, local implementation route, policy signal, or research only. Assign target, role, revenue motion, caveat, and next-check date.

Days 16-20: Qualify the top five

Score fit, eligibility, geography, timing, finance, capacity, target clarity, and source confidence. Run finance and program reviews on the strongest routes. Reject attractive but structurally poor fits and record why.

Days 21-25: Activate contact paths

Attend public or bidder sessions, submit permitted clarification questions, contact intermediaries about their process, and identify appropriate recipient or procurement roles. Prepare a short capability statement or partnership note tied to the sourced need; do not send a generic grant-seeking message.

Days 26-30: Decide and operationalize

Make bid, partner, monitor, or reject decisions. Put qualified rows into the Opportunity Action Table with owners and dates. Establish weekly monitoring for active pursuits and monthly monitoring for longer-horizon signals. Review outcomes after 30 days and refine search concepts based on validated and rejected records.

Limits and responsible use

- A federal program, Assistance Listing, appropriation, forecast, or historical award is not necessarily an open opportunity.
- An obligation is a promise to spend; it is not the same as an outlay or a recipient's available cash.
- A prime recipient is not automatically a buyer, partner, or pass-through entity for the service being researched.
- Subrecipient and contractor classifications depend on the substance of the relationship and the pass-through entity's determination.
- Eligibility summaries do not replace the full NOFO, solicitation, statute, regulation, or local instructions.
- Award and subaward data can lag, change, contain recipient-name variations, or omit local context. Department of Defense contract and subcontract data on USAspending have a stated 90-day display delay.
- State and local portals use different fiscal years, terminology, and update practices. Preserve the jurisdiction and retrieval date.
- Match, indirect costs, audit requirements, reimbursement timing, and allowable costs require award-specific finance and compliance review.
- Public contact information should be used for its stated purpose. Respect question windows, procurement rules, privacy, and communication restrictions.
- Opportunity Scanner supports research and workflow decisions; it does not promise an award or replace professional review.

Evidence and source ledger

Claim or use	Official primary source	Retrieval date	Caveat
Grants, cooperative agreements, lifecycle, and public-purpose context	Grants.gov, official source	2026-07-11	General federal guidance; the specific NOFO controls.
Contract versus grant versus cooperative agreement distinction	Grants.gov, official source	2026-07-11	Summary of governing distinction; review current award terms and law.
Nonprofit eligibility categories and need to verify each notice	Grants.gov, official source	2026-07-11	General eligibility categories do not establish eligibility for a particular NOFO.
Organization registration, UEI, and applicant setup	Grants.gov, official source	2026-07-11	Processing can take time; verify current instructions.
SAM registration purpose and 365-day renewal	SAM.gov, official source	2026-07-11	A UEI alone is not an active registration for direct federal awards.
Assistance Listings, contract opportunities, and official SAM functions	SAM.gov, official source	2026-07-11	An Assistance Listing is program information, not proof of an open competition.
Award, subaward, obligation, and outlay definitions	USAspending, official source	2026-07-11	Award data requires period, measure, and record-type interpretation.
Prime award and subaward downloads and DOD 90-day delay	USAspending, official source	2026-07-11	Reporting can lag; downloaded records do not prove current availability.
HHS grant and recipient research	HHS TAGGS, official source	2026-07-11	HHS-specific assistance data; verify against current agency and award documents.
Subrecipient versus contractor determination	GovInfo, 2 CFR 200.331, official source	2026-07-11	Substance controls; pass-through entity makes case-by-case determination.
Pass-through entity responsibilities	GovInfo, 2 CFR 200.332, official source	2026-07-11	Annual CFR edition; check current eCFR and award-specific requirements.
15 percent de minimis indirect cost option	CFO Council 2024 revision guide, official source	2026-07-11	Applies subject to 2 CFR 200.414, agency implementation, statute, and award terms.
\$1 million federal-award expenditure audit threshold from October 1, 2024	HHS Grants Policy Statement, official source	2026-07-11	Threshold concerns expenditures during the entity's fiscal year, not award face value.
WIOA state and local implementation context	DOL, official source	2026-07-11	Program structure; inspect the relevant state plan and local board.
Program Year 2026 WIOA allotments to states and outlying areas	DOL TEGL 10-25, official source	2026-07-11	State allotment evidence, not a direct nonprofit opportunity.
Community Services Block Grant local network and state flexibility	HHS, official source	2026-07-11	Program overview; verify the state administering agency and current local process.
FY2026 AmeriCorps single-state route and deadlines	AmeriCorps, official source	2026-07-11	March 31, 2026 federal deadline has passed; state deadlines could have been earlier.
FY2026 CoC registration timing and FY2024 award context	HUD, official source	2026-07-11	Registration is not the full competition; HUD said FY2026 detailed resources were forthcoming.
Agency procurement forecast directory	Acquisition.gov, official source	2026-07-11	Forecasts are planning signals, not solicitations or guaranteed acquisitions.

Put this guide to work

Opportunity Scanner reads your company website, finds source-backed public-sector signals, and translates them into target organizations, revenue motions, contact paths, and next actions.

Run a free company scan at opportunityscanner.ai

Recheck official sources before any outreach, application, registration, or bid decision.